

A Googly for Shah Rukh

The first questions about how the IPL will actually work and how its spoils will be shared are asked in an agitated Kolkata

Call it the moment of impact, or the first sign of trouble. Now that players have been bought and teams formed, the brave, new monetised world of the Indian Premier League (IPL) has run up against the old, established workings of the BCCI. The Eden Gardens—India's grandest cricket ground and home of its IPL team, the Kolkata Knight Riders—is where the first real questions around the IPL and the share of its spoils have been raised.

SOUMITRO GHOSH



SUVASHIS MULLICK

GRANDSTAND: Eden Gardens (above) is the centre of all protests

Eighty-five out of a total of 121 affiliated units, i.e., the voting members of the Cricket Association of Bengal (CAB) have signed a memorandum demanding that 70 per cent of the funds coming to the CAB from the IPL should be distributed to them for better infrastructure and "overall development of Bengal cricket". The relegation of Bengal to the Plate (lower) division of the Ranji Trophy has caused concern in the state, with fingers indiscriminately pointed at the present CAB regime, led by its president Prasun Mukherjee.

While the protesting affiliates—who can now be called the opposition—have good reason to be concerned about the state's cricket, the financial windfall expected from the IPL has more than played its part in their raising demands.

When the CAB met for a special general meeting (SGM) earlier this week,

the presence of one man indicated to all present that Mukherjee and his men had a fight on their hands.

Former BCCI and CAB president Jagmohan Dalmiya is now the voice of the protesting affiliates. He appeared at the SGM with majority of the affiliated units of CAB rallying behind him, a portent perhaps for the CAB's June elections. The SGM concluded on a note of temporary peace empowering Mukherjee to negotiate with Shah Rukh

Rs 10 crore plus Rs 50 lakh per match).

Along with a share of the IPL booty, the opposition affiliates have also raised a demand for a large share of tickets. CAB members—life, annual and associate—traditionally get complimentary tickets for all matches held at the Eden. Mukherjee claimed that for the seven IPL matches, the CAB was not legally bound to distribute the tickets, as it was Red Chillies and not the CAB who were the organisers.

Dalmiya maintained that tickets had to be distributed to avoid 'trouble' in staging the matches. Dalmiya's formula offered as a solution was typically, fiendishly simple. Give the Kolkata team exactly the same number of tickets as the IPL team with the next biggest ground, leaving the rest for distribution.

SUBIR HALDER



SUVASHIS MULLICK



Dalmiya (left) has taken up the cause of agitated Bengal affiliates turning the heat on Mukherjee.



Khan's Red Chillies Entertainment, organisers of Kolkata's IPL matches. But Dalmiya did ominously declare that the dissatisfied would "not give in till their demands are met" and the BCCI would "never be allowed" to take the IPL matches away from Kolkata. After the meeting Mukherjee said, "I will talk to the organisers about the demands."

Mukherjee said the BCCI, in a letter to the CAB, had stated that CAB would definitely get at least Rs 7 crore (as against the earlier expected figure of

Given that the Eden seats 90,000 and the most tickets any other IPL team would sell is 40,000, the CAB should have 50,000 tickets to hand out. But giving away tickets for free will eat into one of the few revenue streams available to teams in the IPL. The rumblings in Kolkata should act as an alarm bell for the ruling CAB regime as well as the other IPL teams who will soon all be running into the labyrinthine maze of the BCCI's headstrong and politically savvy state associations. **by Elora Sen**